who took home Album of the Year for *We Are* in 2022—has a repertoire so eclectic that he has tried to find different ways to explain "the genre of Jon Batiste". In 2013, he coined 'Social Music' to "describe his philosophy and the intention of the music, which is to bring all the different forms of human creativity under one tent". It served as the title of a record with his group Stay Human, which was the house band of *The Late Show with Stephen Colbert* from 2015 to 2022.

> Batiste's 2025 album ***Big Money*** incorporates reggae, R&B, folk and bluegrass, to name a few

More recently, he used 'New Americana' to classify the songs on his 2025 album *Big Money*, which incorporate reggae, R&B, folk and bluegrass, to name just a few. That, he says, was a way to reclaim the genre of Americana, which he feels "is limited in scope and leaves out a lot of music from people who are marginalised". Says Batiste, "If there's going to be a term that describes not just the music of America, but the mythology and all the different icons, like baseball and apple pie, then if it doesn't include all people, it can't be accurate."

Throughout his career, Batiste—who won an Oscar in 2021 for Best Original Score for his work in the film *Soul*—has "been a proponent of no genres, just expressions". And it's when his audience goes through "a very full range of human expression and emotion" that he knows he has delivered a successful event. Those include "moments where it becomes very meditative or pensive, where we're dancing in the aisles, and where I'm really wanting to display the virtuosity of music. My goal is to create a show that touches all of these places".

The composer hopes to return to India with a full band to deliver the kind of electrifying experience he first came to be known for through the impromptu street performances he would stage in New York City. Those gigs, which he called 'love riots', would often feature Indian-American singer Falu as part of the ensemble.

The Maestro concerts will give us one facet of the many sides of the multidimensional artist. "I thought about coming with the band, but it always feels very special to introduce myself in a very direct, stripped-down way first," says Batiste. "It's almost like you're meeting everybody one to one." ■

—Amit Gurbaxani

Bharat Mandapam Plenary Hall, Delhi, on Monday, Nov. 24; NMACC, The Grand Theatre, Mumbai, on Wednesday, Nov. 26. Tickets: Bookmyshow.com



ROLAND COELHO

AUTUMN SONATA *The orchestra* and, left, Ambassador Nirupama Rao, founder, South Asian Symphony Foundation

November 30, at the M.S. Subbulakshmi Arangam. The Chennai programme also includes Mozart's Symphony No. 40 and popular opera excerpts.

The weekend also features a public lecture by Professor Katherine Butler Schofield of King's College London at the Bangalore International Centre (BIC) on November 28. Her talk, 'Strings Across the Ocean', examines centuries of musical exchange between India and Europe. Ambassador Nirupama Rao, founder of the South Asian Symphony Foundation (SASF), which has brought the orchestra together, situates this history within a broader ethic of cultural diplomacy. "The historical exchanges between India and Europe have enriched both musical worlds. SASO continues this heritage." For Rao, SASO is the culmination of a vision shaped by decades of service. "In South Asia, where histories often divide, music reclaims our shared humanity," she notes. Beethoven's Ninth Symphony, the centrepiece of the Bengaluru concert, reflects this vision. "Beethoven's Ninth is both a celebration and a call," Rao says. SASO's message is clear: in a world of many voices, harmony remains necessary, beginning with the simple, radical act of listening. ■

—Nikhil Sardana